ENT INTO A TAILSPIN

UNDER THE NEW RULES, CAUSING A NATIONWIDE FLIGHT MELTDOWN

THE DECEPTION GAME

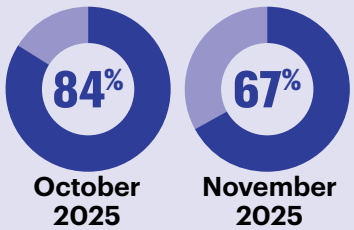
- In four meetings with DGCA around the Nov. 1 rollout, **IndiGo brass maintains they are ready** for the new pilot norms
- DGCA fails to scrutinise IndiGo's claims; allows it to **increase winter operations by 10%** from the previous year's winter schedule

THE CRACKS SHOW

- IndiGo's crew management system, which autogenerates **pilot rosters using complex calculations, begins to wobble** after new FDTL rules are fed in November
- Around **1,200 flights are cancelled in November**, but since it's around 2 per cent of total, IndiGo tells DGCA all's under control on Dec. 1

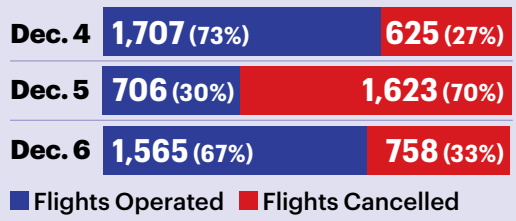
ON-TIME PERFORMANCE

A 17 percentage point drop in just a month



THE ROSTER COLLAPSE

- On **Dec. 4**, all hell breaks loose as **crew management software goes haywire; 625 flights** get cancelled
- System collapses again on **Dec. 5**, with **1,623 flights cancelled**, unleashing mayhem across airports. Thousands of passengers impacted



THE FALLOUT

- Fares peak, **surging by 700-1,600%** on domestic flights till DGCA imposes caps

THE FARE SURGE

DELHI–BENGALURU

Avg. fare ₹4,500 ▶ Shot up to ₹80,000

- DGCA begins inquiry; **cuts 10% of IndiGo's flights**; deploys officials in its offices

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY



"INDIGO BELIEVED THEY WERE SO BIG, SO INFLUENTIAL, THAT IF THEY SHOWED RELUCTANCE, THE DGCA WOULD BLINK. THEY THOUGHT THE RULES DID NOT APPLY TO THEM"

— CAPT. G.R. GOPINATH, FOUNDER, AIR DECCAN

unprecedented 2,948 domestic flights were cancelled, 1,588 on December 5 alone. Tens of thousands of passengers were stranded in lounges, clogging airports. Airfares spiked to stratospheric levels, as passengers desperately bought tickets on other airlines. The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) stepped in not only to control the upward spiralling fares but to crack down hard on IndiGo's alleged irresponsibility and callousness in handling the crisis. Before the current meltdown, IndiGo's market cap stood at $25 billion (Rs 2.3 lakh crore) and profits after tax for FY25 at a whopping Rs 7,258 crore. How, then, did the IndiGo management lose control so spectacularly? While IndiGo should shoulder a major part of the blame, India's aviation regulators, including the DGCA, are also culpable. Here's why: